

Scenario Design Doc for The Contract RPG

Title: It's Cleanup Day!

Role: Solo Designer

Platform: The Contract RPG ([Community Scenario Exchange](#))

Genre: Horror / Investigation / Supernatural

Project Type: Published TTRPG Adventure

Note: Whilst I cannot directly share a link to *It's Cleanup Day!* without the user in question having an account, I've created a profile you can use to view it! Please reach out to me via email if you're interested.

About the System:

This scenario was written for The Contract RPG, a tabletop roleplaying game centered around the completion of Contracts for the mysterious Harbingers, entities that grant people with unladen potential the ability to find their inner strengths and amplify them. These Contracts, written as scenarios, are meant to be played in one sitting as a "one-shot", and can be any variety of supernatural story in any setting. Traditionally, stories are told in a Modern Sci-Fi/Supernatural setting, as is the scenario we'll be covering today.

Design Goals:

- Fabricate a story adjacent to reality by using real-world references, features, and materials.
- Encourage multiple solutions to solving any given problem, accounting for failure.
- Implement a moral dilemma that requires players to think on their feet and make tough decisions.
- Add an engaging puzzle/minigame that fits within the bounds of The Contract's ruleset.
- Set the tone with a foray into the Sci-Fi Horror aspect of The Contract.

What I Worked On:

- Designed a complete TTRPG one-shot from concept to publication.
- Wrote narrative, dialogue, encounters, and all supplementary material necessary to run a session of the Contract RPG.
- Researched real-world locations and languages to make for an authentic experience that encourages the GM to immerse their players.
- Provided GMs with an official organization and supporting backstory to use the factions and discoveries in-game in their own homebrewed game settings.
- Crafted a sequential, objective-based adventure with investigative and puzzle-solving elements

Summary:

Overview:

It's Cleanup Day! Is a scenario designed with Newbie (low level) Contractors in mind. It's a Sci-Fi Horror adventure split into three parts (The Meeting, Search and Destroy, and The Escape). Players are tasked with planting a vaporizer in a radioactive exclusion zone to clear all evidence of a large company's wrongdoings. They also must retrieve a specific solid state drive from a computer terminal onsite. Failure to comply or complete their Contract may spell death for the players... or worse.

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Narrative Design:

The scenario, written for the GM running the game, is written in such a way that mechanics are baked into the narrative, and the two are clearly delineated between each other. To the left is an example of the story structure, taken as a screenshot from the Contact RPG website. For an excerpt from the Scenario with commentary, please find the **Writing Samples** section below.

Obstacle Design:

In the Contract there are encounters known as obstacles that require the player characters to engage with the world around them in combat, puzzles, social encounters, and more. A Contract will usually have three major obstacles and any number of minor obstacles. This one is no exception. There are three major obstacles that each respectively touch on the three major types. A social encounter (The Exclusion Zone), a puzzle (The Power Plant), and combat (The Compound).

Systems Design:

During the game's creation, I also had the need to consider how players would interact with the game mechanics in tandem with the narrative. GMs running the adventure are provided with points of interest and callouts that direct them to ask the players for specific checks throughout the game.

Writing Samples:

The Lobby

The contractors will finally meet at a massive glass skyscraper deep in the heart of the city. You can have this happen at any time of day you wish, and let them arrive a bit early before their meeting to let them mingle with each other and interact with the environment. Through the sliding doors is a pristine marbled black and white room, with tall pillars that stretch toward the ceiling, a central decorative fountain, and multiple sitting areas with leather couches and glass side tables. In the back is a desk where a man and woman work tirelessly from their computers. They do not look up as the Contractors enter, and will not engage unless spoken to directly.

If a Contractor manages to grab their attention, they are both well-spoken and proficient in English, assuring the Contractors that someone will be with them shortly. If anyone attempts to use a particularly complicated vernacular, the woman will procure a small electronic English-Korean dictionary to better respond to and address them. They will disclose the following information if asked:¹

- Yes, the building has no name. Just an address.
- They do not know who the Contractors are meeting. The building hosts conferences and events for a variety of businesses.
- They are free to relax in the lobby, but the elevators/stairs are locked to guests and visitors. They will need an escort.

Exactly 5 minutes before their scheduled meeting, an elevator will ding, revealing a very handsome Korean man in his late 40's. He sports a full black suit and red tie, slicked black hair, and thin gold-framed glasses. He approaches the Contractors with a smile on his face and introduces himself as CIO of the Seoul Coalition, Kim Hyeon-Jeong.

Mr. Kim knows each contractor by their face and name, and speaks English perfectly.² Any particularly astute Contractor will notice Mr. Kim's eye twitch in anger if anyone upsets him, even if the smile stays plastered on his face. Calling Mr. Kim anything but, is one of the many things that upsets him. He is proper and polite, and expects the same of his hired help. He will ask that the Contractors follow him into the elevator, taking them to the 100th floor (of 120). If anyone tries to ask Mr. Kim a question, he states that he will better be able to address them once they are within the private office he has reserved for their meeting.³

1 - Many sections of the document require players to engage with their surroundings to learn more information. This is intentional to reward roleplay and engagement with game mechanics.

2 - You'll notice I often state an individual's fluency levels over the course of the document. This harkens to my goal of creating a story in a believable setting. It is not necessary for players to understand certain words, phrases, or documents they may find on their adventure, but creative problem solving can pay off.

3 - Descriptions and narrative design are woven into gameplay advice to assist GMs for easy reading and implementation. All sections to be read aloud are clearly delineated as well.

The SSD

Following the claw marks left by the beast will eventually bring contractors to a room labeled 실험-03 (silheom-03, experiment-03). This is the birthplace of EX-03, and now a nest of cables, computers, metal, and scrap that seems to blossom out from the open metal security door. The SSD is inside. Making one's way through the tangle of wires and metal is dangerous. Contractors can roll **Dexterity + Athletics** to carefully avoid potentially dangerous hazards lurking within. Failure may cause a Severity 1 or 2 injury cutting oneself on a stray metal partition curling in from the wall, floor, or ceiling. A successful roll in **Perception + Technology, Difficulty 7**¹ will find the SSD the Contractors have been tasked with finding, but there are easily hundreds of storage drives in every direction. When the Contractors find the SSD, you may read this aloud:

- Pushing to the back of the room, you find a now almost unrecognizable stainless steel countertop. Wires seem to sprout from the sink drain as if purposefully woven through every gap and crevasse, covering what was once a shining metal surface. Solid state drives dangle from the ceiling like fruit from the vine, and many lie in heaps around discarded monitors and tempered glass. One computer stands out, the white sticker on the attached monitor says - Admin. The screen permanently burned with the image of the last-viewed file. White and black pixels display a page detailing an experimental weapon and its tests being fueled by a variety of different unorthodox substances and materials. In the carcass of the computer tower you spot it... Mainframe 005, still plugged in.

Soon after they retrieve the SSD, EX-03 will emerge from the shadows. See what happens during the Contractors' first encounter by reading the appropriate section in - The Beast. If the players have not yet gathered the clues necessary to outsmart EX-03, you can give them a small hint² as it emerges from the end of the hall:

- Your blood runs cold as you peer down the empty hallway, a green glow pulsing in the dark. A shape rises, reaching the 40-foot ceilings with ease as it bobs and weaves ever closer. Glistening black pincers. Hundreds of legs. A long segmented carapace. It dives toward the ground with a thud that echoes through The Compound, raring to charge. As the dust settles, you watch a flashlight jostled by the sudden earthquake flicker ever so slightly. The creature turns its head violently, and begins to siphon the light directly from the source. You hear a loud pop as the bulb explodes, and the hallway goes black.

Now is when the Contractors run.³

1 - An example of checks that were implemented to ensure players are rolling dice and taking actions that feel weighty. The goal is to keep players engaged and active, especially during tense moments.

2 - I always ensure the GM is provided with backup options in case things go south. Sometimes, players won't have all the info they need due to poor planning or unforeseen consequences.

3 - The combat laid out after this is against an enemy that is not defeatable by brute force. Combat in The Contract has the potential to be one-sided. Players are given a fighting chance, but they need to use what they've learned from the narrative to creatively escape their peril.

Retrospective:

Challenges and Rewards:

As someone who came from D&D, I was familiar with crafting my own adventures, but I certainly ran into some obstacles of my own nonetheless.

- The Setting
 - Riding the line between realistic and fantastical in a setting unfamiliar to me was a struggle. I often wrote about fantasy before this project, so it took some time to play the game and learn before I felt ready. I was able to better learn how to adapt to new styles.
- Designing Obstacles (Encounters)
 - Ensuring I was making obstacles not too hard or too easy, and that they had multiple solutions, was certainly a lot of work. It helped immensely with strengthening my game design skills, and maintaining the set project scope as the solo writer for a project that needs to be both fun for the players, and tell a good story.
- Formatting
 - I was unfamiliar with the process of publishing my work before designing with The Contract RPG's tools. Whilst the options provided were immensely helpful, I still spent a lot of time learning how to make everything visually appealing and easy to follow. GMs running a game need to be able to jump around between sections of a document at any given time.

Closing Remarks:

Thank you so much for reading my design doc of *It's Cleanup Day!*, please let me know if you'd like to read more, and if you have any additional questions about my work.